



MICHAL WALUSZA/FIDE

Tough luck: No. 2 and 3 seeds, Arjun Erigaisi (above, right) and R. Praggnanandhaa (left), had disappointing runs in the World Cup.

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Wei then made sure of his trip to Cyprus after winning his semifinal against Russia's Andrey Esipenko. That match produced the tournament's most dramatic moment.

The 23-year-old Russian was in a commanding position, but he made a terrible mistake: he overlooked his hanging rook while going for a pawn push on the other side of the board. Wei immediately grabbed the rook with his knight.

Esipenko realised his folly, resigned immediately and stared at the board for a few seconds before getting up and quickly walking out of the playing hall: he had just squandered a place in the World Cup final.

He, however, showed resilience, as he came back the following day for the third-place play-off against Uzbekistan's Nodirbek Yakubboev.

Esipenko won it convincingly, without having to play the tie-breaks. His victory in the opening game was

enough. A couple of dubious moves had put the Uzbek in an inferior position from early on, and there was no coming back for him.

The second game was drawn, and thus Esipenko, one of the rising young stars from Russia — which is no longer the dominant force it once was — clinched the last available slot for the Candidates. "It is the best performance of my career," he remarked.

The winning trio from Goa will be joined in Cyprus by Anish Giri and Matthias Bluebaum who had qualified for the Candidates by taking the two spots at the Grand Swiss tournament. There will also be Fabiano Caruana, the World No. 3 from the United States, who made it as the winner of the 2024 FIDE Circuit. World No. 2 Hikaru Nakamura, also from the USA, is most likely to qualify as the player with the highest average rating. Lastly, R. Praggnanandhaa is expected to complete the line-up as the winner of the 2025 FIDE Circuit.

Apart from Praggnanandhaa, Giri and Bluebaum were also in Goa for the World Cup, but they couldn't last long. Giri was actually the